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Ethics Essay

When it comes to engineering, there is nothing more important than ethics. Every engineer will face an ethical dilemma at some point in their career, so ethics must be discussed and practiced. Engineers use many references for ethics, such as the IEEE Code of Ethics, the 5 P's of Ethics, and Virtue of Ethics, to build ethically solid navigation skills and to reference when confronted with an ethical dilemma.

Firstly, what is the purpose of having and following a Code of Ethics? A Code of Ethics aims to accept responsibility for our decisions' impact as engineers and to provide an outline of what is expected as a result. It details the ethical obligations that are associated with this career. It is important to follow this code in other aspects of life so that it is a part of our daily decision-making process and comes automatically. When faced with an ethical dilemma, I don't immediately reference the Code of Ethics. I make my initial decision off virtue ethics and fall back on the Code of Ethics if the dilemma isn't so obvious.

In continuation, during this class we discussed multiple ethical issues. Some issues discussed were the ethical issue of the Ford Pinto and public safety and the Amazon Alexa privacy issue. Most classmates agreed about the Ford Pinto situation, where malicious intent caused a huge public safety issue. Ford engineers looked the other way when they discovered a safety issue and signed off on a design willingly endangering the

public and leading to many fatal crashes to save some money. This situation is very obviously a violation of the Code of Ethics, specifically line 1, about accepting responsibility for the safety and welfare of the public. However, the Amazon Alexa issue was much less straightforward. Some people leaned in favor of Amazon providing the police with any information they had relating to a crime. Sharing user information is a bad look for Amazon, and a conflict of interest arises as to whether they should share information if it may impact sales. I lean more neutral about this and believe that even though Amazon has a user agreement that allows them to disclose information as they choose, they should prioritize the users' privacy unless proper authority demands access to user data through a warrant.

Finally, Virtue of Ethics can be related to the Amazon Alexa case study. Of the six virtues, integrity, honesty, fidelity, charity, responsibility, and self-discipline, I find that honesty, fidelity, and responsibility are the most important in this case. Honesty describes being open and fair as well as trustworthy. All these qualities are essential for Amazon to consider when deciding whether to protect the end user's data. Fidelity is being faithful to the people in your life as well as the public. Amazon should remain faithful to the public and avoid sharing user data. Lastly, responsibility is recognizing the obligation to act for the good of others. It is integral that Amazon holds its responsibility to the public highly and does not waver under outside pressure to change. Other virtues do not apply as closely as these three, except for integrity, which goes hand in hand with responsibility. Charity and self-discipline are mostly irrelevant as it primarily focuses on protecting user privacy. Charity could be argued that it relates to Amazon volunteering information to police without a warrant as this could be seen as goodwill and volunteering help to

others, but that is not as strong of a connection as the previously mentioned virtues. Self-discipline is almost irrelevant as this issue does not involve overindulgence or restraint.

In conclusion, ethics remain a crucial part of being a successful engineer, and it is vital that they are practiced daily whenever ethical dilemmas arise. There are many resources for deriving ethical guidance, such as the IEEE Code of Ethics, the 5 P's of Ethics, and Virtue of Ethics, which should be referenced whenever these issues arise.